

plummeted immediately after the tenth pressing. Instead of dopamine being released when the brain received a reward, it was released in anticipation of one.

Our desires may be manufactured, but our dopamine is real. And most of the dopamine released in our shopping isn't in getting the things, it's in the act of shopping. A fact that hasn't gone unnoticed by financial technology companies. If marketers are focused on your desires and insecurities, fintech companies are manufacturing the experience of shopping. They are always looking for ways to make the experience of shopping more "frictionless."

I (Jen) was scrolling Instagram recently and saw an ad for an adult paint-by-numbers kit. Now, I am a horrible artist and get very frustrated by how bad I am. But in that moment, I wanted what that girl in the picture had! That relaxing experience and a piece of art to show for it! I just knew it would be better than the freehand forest I painted at that sip and paint five years ago. And all I had to do was click the picture. My credit card info and address were saved in the app, my three-digit code memorized. And the kit was on sale FOR A LIMITED TIME ONLY! It was so easy, I didn't even have to think about it.

Fortunately, the kit was more money than I was willing to spend on an experiment in happiness, but I'll admit, they had me on that checkout page in less than a second, and it could've been on its way to my house before I had a chance to remember my bad hand-eye coordination extends to art.

Companies like PayPal, Apple Pay, Affirm, and more exist to make buying as quick and easy as possible. They capitalize on that anticipatory dopamine and have a receipt in your inbox before you know what happened.

It might seem like the world is a perfect storm of internal and external forces all in cahoots to get you to buy more and more. And you wouldn't be wrong, but it doesn't mean there aren't ways to weather that storm. And in weathering it, get closer to the things you want most in life.

DIY Dopamine Fast

For her patients with habits and addictions not at risk for life-threatening withdrawals, like gaming, smoking, and shopping, Lembke uses a